

Arab Street Worry

There are growing concerns that India is not doing enough to engage the Arab World and is losing its influence in a vital region

There is growing concern that by pushing for a strategic relationship with the US, especially through the nuclear deal, India may be alienating the Arab Street with which it has had a long-standing relationship. Experts feel India has not done enough in recent times to engage Middle East countries. "It makes pragmatic sense that if we are developing relations with the US, we should be seen engaging closely with the Arab world, which have been our traditional partners," admits a senior Ministry of External Affairs functionary.

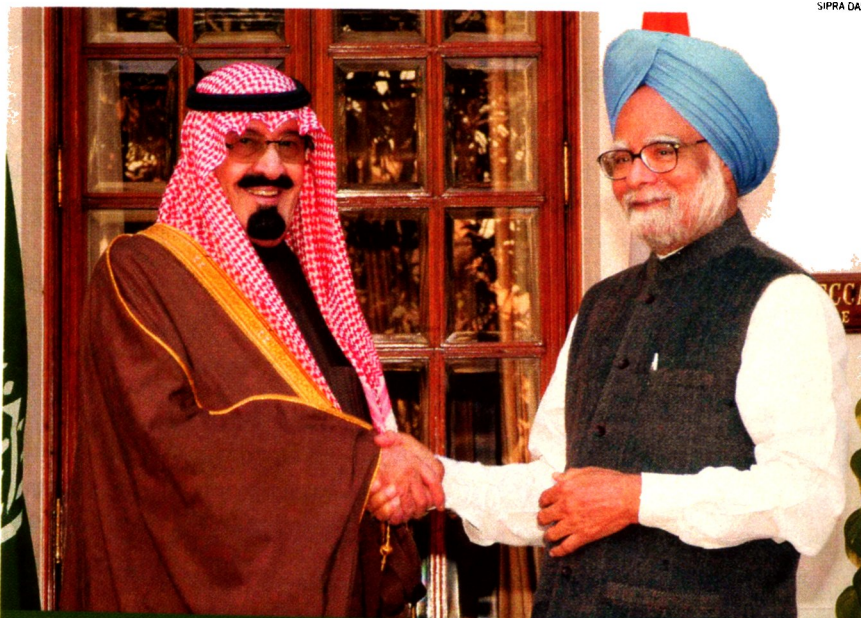
It is not that India has kept out of the Arab circuit. In the last three-and-a-half years of the UPA regime, there have been almost a dozen high-profile visits from the Gulf countries including the King of Saudi Arabia, King of Jordan, Emir of Kuwait and Qatar. Yet the real issue is that there has so far not been a reciprocal prime ministerial visit to emphasise the importance that India places on such relationships. Nor does having a special envoy for Middle East in Chinmay Gharekhan seems to have given the necessary push as the former diplomat has only been used sparingly.

Officials say while a visit of the prime minister to Saudi Arabia was in the works, it ran into scheduling problems. "Invitations to the prime minister are pending. We are now focussing on people-to-people contacts," remarked a senior MEA official.

There are also domestic political compulsions of the need to engage with the Muslim world to reassure its own substantial minority within the country that India is not embarking on a confrontationist approach. However beyond the electoral concerns, the real story is that India has to do more to gain its traditional foothold amongst the Arab countries, for strategic reasons. The Gulf region is more than just an employment destination for more than 4.5-million Indian diaspora. The growing economic inter-

est in the region has added a new dimension to the relationship. India is fast becoming an attractive investment destination. Bilateral trade with the region is now close to \$22.5 billion (Rs 88,400 crore). But while the relationship is on the upswing, trust is yet to come by. Despite India's long-term

DISTANT: King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia with Manmohan Singh



A number of leaders from the Gulf have visited India but there has been no reciprocal Prime Ministerial visit.

strategic stakes in Middle East, which lies in its extended neighbourhood, just 350 km away from India, an ad hoc approach has stymied the relationship.

Another important reason why India needs to revamp its Gulf policy is the fact that it has a shared interest in the stability of the Middle East. Instability in the region will have an adverse impact on the country's economy since 70 per cent of its oil and gas comes from the Gulf region and has a direct bearing on the economy. "We are not giving enough attention to the Gulf relative to its importance for India. We have vital economic stakes in the region and more engagement with the region

at all levels is important for our energy security," says Ishrat Aziz, former Indian envoy to Saudi Arabia.

Security cooperation too has fuelled the relationship, with many Gulf countries now becoming more receptive to India's security concerns. From the times, when Dubai had become a safe haven for Indian mafia dons like Dawood Ibrahim and his associates, there has been a sea change in their mindset. The authorities there have been able to effect a clampdown on these groups and force them to shift their base. In the recent past, Dubai has deported many Indian fugitives. Another country affected by India's growing engagement with the

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US is Syria, which has been waiting to get its Presidential visit from Delhi. India has put it on the back burner lest it create problems. However, problems still linger, although the country did raise its concerns on the wider problem of money laundering and the need to check it as this, could be linked to international terrorist groups, some lacunae remain. Some of the Gulf countries have continued to overlook genuine humanitarian concerns of Indian workers. Beyond the realm of realpolitik what is needed is a more proactive Gulf policy, consistent with the country's long-term strategic interests.

by Saurabh Shukla